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Democracy Dies in Darkness

THURSDAY, MAY 8, 2025 • \$4

DOGE aims to pool vast troves of federal data

Effort frequently violates key security guardrails, government workers say

BY HANNAH NATANSON, JOSEPH MENN, LISA REIN AND RACHEL SIEGEL

The U.S. DOGE Service is racing to build a single centralized database with vast troves of personal information about millions of U.S. citizens and residents, a campaign that often violates or disregards core privacy and security protections meant to keep such information safe, government workers say.

The team overseen by Elon Musk is collecting data from across the government, sometimes at the urging of low-level aides, according to multiple federal employees and a former DOGE staffer, who all spoke on the condition of anonymity for fear of reprisals. The intensifying effort to unify systems into one central hub aims to advance multiple Trump administration priorities, including finding and deporting undocumented immigrants and rooting out fraud in government payments. And it follows a March executive order to eliminate “information silos” as DOGE tries to streamline operations and cut spending.

At several agencies, DOGE officials have sought to merge databases that had long been kept separate, federal workers said. For example, longtime Musk lieutenant Steve Davis told staffers at the

SEE **DOGE** ON **A2**

Food agenda: RFK Jr. leans on his bully pulpit to enact changes. **A5**

Disinformation: The path of a false viral video about USAID. **A13**

U.S. pushes Starlink deals amid trade war

Nations were asked to clear hurdles for Musk’s business, cables show

BY JEFF STEIN AND HANNAH NATANSON

Less than two weeks after President Donald Trump announced 50 percent tariffs on goods from the tiny African nation of Lesotho, the country’s communications regulator held a meeting with representatives of Starlink.

The satellite business, owned by billionaire and Trump adviser Elon Musk’s SpaceX company, had been seeking access to customers in Lesotho. But it was not until Trump unveiled the tariffs and called for negotiations over trade deals that leaders of the country of roughly 2 million people awarded Musk’s firm the nation’s first-ever satellite internet service license, slated to last for 10 years.

The decision drew a mention in an internal State Department memo obtained by The Washington Post, which states: “As the government of Lesotho negotiates a trade deal with the United

SEE **STARLINK** ON **A14**



People watch the cardinal electors on a giant screen installed in St. Peter’s Square at the Vatican as the conclave begins Wednesday.

Papal conclave’s first vote is inconclusive

Eyes await white smoke signaling the election of Francis’s successor

BY ANTHONY FAIOLA AND MICHELLE BOORSTEIN

VATICAN CITY — Black smoke billowing from the chimney of the Sistine Chapel on Wednesday evening signaled an inconclusive first vote to pick the next pontiff, pushing the next ballots until Thursday after a day of Latin chants echoing off sacred marble

halls and a high procession of cardinals, the next pope surely among them.

After a cry by an archbishop of “Extra omnes,” or everyone out, the doors of the Sistine Chapel were shut around 5:44 p.m. as the conclave began amid hermetic secrecy. Speculation swirled that the throne of St. Peter could go to a first pontiff from the United States. Just as many voices were heralding the chances of three Italians and a come-from-behind Spaniard serving in Morocco. A Filipino, a Frenchman, a Congolese and a long-monastic Swede are talks of the town, too.

Yet as all eyes await the white

smoke signaling Habemus Papam — “We have a pope” — the wisest watchers have a warning. Nobody *really* knows who will be the next pope, at a time of deep church division.

More than three hours after the conclave began, the smoke appeared. A crowd assembled outside the chapel roared, then started to disperse when it was clear that there was no new pope. Ismael Rivera, 43, a computer engineer from Peru who was visiting with his family, said he knew the selection of a pope was unlikely after a first vote. But “I wanted to be part of it either way,” he said.

The cardinals under the age of 80 — including nearly two dozen from countries that have never had a voice in a conclave before — will be sequestered for votes, released only to retire to their boardinghouse for meals and rest, until a new pope is found. Under the ceiling depicting Michelangelo’s outstretched God creating Adam, there will be no interpreters, no speeches, no lobbying (theoretically). There will be only prayer, chatter and votes.

To keep themselves pure of

SEE **CONCLAVE** ON **A10**

Holy wager: Betting on the new papacy has never been bigger. **C1**

As nomination stalls, Ed Martin’s past fuels doubts

BY TOM JACKMAN AND SPENCER S. HSU

President Donald Trump’s pick for top federal prosecutor in D.C., Ed Martin, has a history of picking fights in public life, attacking political enemies and allies he disagreed with, judges he secretly opposed and subordinates he wrongly fired, a Wash-

ington Post examination of his record over two decades shows.

Martin’s nomination is now faltering in the Senate. But the same headlong style that fed controversies over his 15 weeks as interim U.S. attorney has over the years both fueled his rise through conservative politics and burned him repeatedly, costing him jobs, tens of thousands

of dollars in fines and court contempt citations.

A Republican lawyer, activist and candidate for multiple offices since 2005, Martin rose to high-level posts at the St. Louis election board, Missouri governor’s office and the nonprofit group founded by anti-feminist icon Phyllis Schlafly. He also racked up \$2 million in legal fees

and settlement payments at taxpayers’ expense in a scandal that exposed his efforts to push the Missouri Supreme Court to the right.

Now, Democratic critics say they see a pattern in what they call Martin’s repeated abuse of his powers in office to threaten political opponents, and his in-

SEE **MARTIN** ON **A6**



Former police officers Demetrius Haley, left, and Tadarrius Bean, center, hug Wednesday in Memphis as Justin Smith Jr., right, becomes emotional after the three were found not guilty of state charges.

3 ex-officers acquitted of murdering Tyre Nichols

Videos showed Memphis police repeatedly hitting him after traffic stop

BY EMMANUEL FELTON AND RACHEL HATZIPANAGOS

A state jury found three former Memphis police officers not guilty of second-degree murder in the 2023 beating death of Tyre Nichols that helped galvanize a movement to reform police conduct.

The jurors deliberated for more than eight hours after listening to days of testimony that delved into the minutes after police pulled over Nichols for a traffic stop and when the 29-year-old FedEx worker was repeatedly hit and kicked by the officers.

Tensions at brink for India, Pakistan

ISLAMABAD SAYS 21 KILLED IN STRIKES

Uncertain path forward for shaken rival nations

This article is by Shaiq Hussain, Rick Noack, Karishma Mehrotra, Shams Irfan and Haq Nawaz Khan

ISLAMABAD, PAKISTAN — India and Pakistan were on the brink of direct conflict Wednesday for the first time since 2019, after India launched its deepest and deadliest strikes inside Pakistan in decades and Islamabad claimed to have downed several Indian warplanes.

Pakistan’s government said 21 people were killed in the strikes, including two children; India said it avoided Pakistani military and civilian targets and that the operation was aimed at militants in retaliation for last month’s rampage by gunmen in a popular tourist area in Pahalgam, in Indian-administered Kashmir. India linked the April 22 attack to Pakistan; Islamabad denied any involvement and has appealed for an international investigation.

The overnight attack has rattled Pakistan, a nation of more than 240 million people, which had braced for Indian military action for weeks but had not anticipated the strikes would reach its heartland. At least 16 of the victims were killed in Pakistan’s Punjab, the country’s most populous and wealthiest province. It was the first such Indian attack on Punjab in more than half a century.

While the overnight strikes had echoes of a confrontation between the nuclear-armed powers six years ago, Wednesday’s aerial assault was much more expansive, and its potential consequences more far-reaching. In 2019, after a similar militant attack in Kashmir, India responded with a single strike in a remote part of Pakistan. In the wake of the latest barrage, the countries traded rhetorical blows, with each trying to own the narrative.

“The operation was launched to provide justice to the innocent victims of the terrorist attacks and their families,” Indian Col.

SEE **PAKISTAN** ON **A11**

IN THE NEWS

‘National defense areas’ New military zones on the southern border are creating confusion for the migrants charged with entering them, their lawyers and federal judges. **A4**

D.C. immigrant scrutiny Federal agents have been visiting local restaurants to demand documents, rattling owners and workers. **B1**

THE NATION
In Pennsylvania’s Lehigh Valley, a manufacturing hub, tariffs have set off doubts. **A3**
Another Navy jet fell into the Red Sea, marking the fourth major mishap in months. **A5**

THE WORLD
In Brazil, soybean growers are benefiting from the U.S.-China trade war. **A8**
China’s Xi arrived in Moscow for Putin’s victory parade amid deepening ties. **A12**

THE ECONOMY
An archive system for Signal chats adopted by the Trump administration poses security risks, experts say. **A11**
The Federal Reserve kept interest rates steady as it awaits further clarity on the economic impact of Trump’s tariffs. **A14**

THE REGION
Virginia announced an investigation of Loudoun County schools over an incident in a high school boys’ locker room. **B1**
A killer who hid in plain sight for 23 years pleaded guilty to a 2001 murder after police caught up with him. **B1**

STYLE
Every arts director at the National Endowment for the Arts has exited the federal culture agency. **C1**

LOCAL LIVING
We’ve got the dirt on several window cleaners that are going viral on social media.

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